THE SHARPEST EDGE

Features and performances of the Rafale and the J-10C, India and Pakistan's most advanced fighters



RAFALE VS J10C

RAFALE		J-10C
Rbe2 Aesa (200 km)	RADAR	AESA Radar (200–250 km)
Meteor (150–200 km)	MISSILES	Mica Pl-15e (145 km)
Spectra	EW SUITE	Chinese EW system
Netra, Phalcon	AEW&C SUPPORT	Indigenous Chinese EW
Multirole, Precision Strike	ROLE	Multirole, BVR
36	NUMBERS	25

RAFALE Used SCALP missiles, Hammer bombs with precision, destroying terror hubs in Pakistan on May 7; hit Pak air bases on May 10

J-10C Pakistan claims to have shot down Rafales using PL-15s from J-10Cs; later, without AD support, they kept away as India hit air bases

Defence analyst Shreyas Deshmukh, research associate at the Delhi Policy Group, says that the Rafale vs J-10C comparison reflects a contest for battlefield superiority, given their similar capabilities. Though debris, including PL-15E remnants and possible MICA missile fragments from an IAF jet, were reportedly recovered, Deshmukh asserts that "no concrete evidence supports claims of aerial losses on either side".

INDIA'S AIR DEFENCE EDGE

For India, the real positive to have emerged from Operation Sindoor is the overwhelming success of its integrated air defence system. The two units that synergised perfectly to nullify all projectiles hurled at India are the IAF's Integrated Air Command and Control System (IACCS) and the army's Akashteer. The IACCS is an automated command and control system that integrates data at its control centres from air defence assets like ground-based radar, airborne sensors, AWACS/ AEW&CS, communication nodes and IAF command and control centres. The consolidated data along with real-time updates gives commanders of air defence units an overall situational awareness and full battlefield picture to respond to incoming aerial threats. Similarly, the army's Akashteer is an air defence control and reporting system comprising radars and sensors that are connected to units of its air defence.

With the integration of the resources of IACCS and Akashteer, the Indian air defence threw up a layered grid.